

IBM Watson-powered robot Chintu unveiled

IBM, in collaboration with Maharashtra Institute of Technology (MIT), Pune, has introduced Chintu, a cogni-

tive assistant powered by IBM Watson that will assist senior citizens in conducting everyday tasks. Chintu,

who is under 61cm (2-feet) tall, was developed after MIT Pune received a grant of one million rupees last year from IBM. Chintu can move his hands and read books to an audience.

Vrushali Kulkarni, professor and head of computer engineering department at MIT, Pune, says, "The robot has opened up a new and exciting research avenue for our students. Robotics, machine learning and cognitive computing are interesting and exploring fields of research today, and our students are getting first-hand experience of working in these fields."

Krishnamohan Manmohan, a student at MIT, Pune, adds, "What I like most about Watson is that it can solve real-world problems. These services can be used as and when required, and are always accessible."



Drawing from Watson's domain knowledge, Chintu assists senior citizens in completing tasks like reading the newspaper/book, provide mood based entertainment services for song and dance, and generate reminders on their daily medication (Image courtesy: IBM India)

Wikipedia bots more like humans than expected

Scientists have warned that artificial intelligence systems may behave more like humans than expected. This comes after they found that software robots designed to improve articles on Wikipedia sometimes have online fights over content that can continue for years.

Editing bots on Wikipedia undo vandalism, enforce bans, check spelling, create links and import content automatically, whereas other bots (which are non-editing) can mine data, identify data or identify copyright infringements.

Researchers from University of Oxford and the Alan Turing Institute in the UK have analysed how much they disrupted Wikipedia, observing how they interacted on 13 different

language editions over ten years (from 2001 to 2010).

They found that bots interacted with one another, whether or not this was by design, and it led to unpredictable consequences. Researchers said the bots are more like humans than you might expect. These appear to behave differently in culturally-distinct online environments.

The findings are a warning to those using artificial intelligence for building autonomous vehicles, cyber security systems or managing social media. Although bots are automatons, and do not have the capacity for emotions, bot-to-bot interactions are unpredictable and can act in distinctive ways.